WRITING SAMPLE: NEWSLETTER ARTICLE

RENOWNED PIONEERS OF SOUND

"Wherever I go, I'll record a bunch of new things that will always creatively inspire."

-Johnnie Burn

Some of the best sound engineers and designers in the world made history in pop culture simply by creating the most notable sounds and effects especially for film. Audio design is unfortunately overlooked by casual audiences, though these pioneers have captured their hearts through the art of enhancing sound. A sound designer's main goal in film is to allow the audience to enhance an emotional connection to the story by creating sounds that fit best in certain scenes. Not only can they inform the viewer of offscreen red herrings but build anticipation which can lead to surprises and plot twists. Three renowned sound engineers/designers provided below had previously done work on Star Wars, Jurassic Park, and the recent horror Nope.

CHRISTOPHER BOYES

Since 1991, Christopher Boyes worked on seventy films while adopting a few different roles in sound typically for film. As a foley recordist for Jurassic Park, he states that he enjoys creating supernatural-like sounds, "ethereal" to be exact. Afterwards while working as a sound editor for Pearl Harbor, he was responsible for selecting and assembling sound recordings for final sound mixing. While in Costa Rica prior to the release of The Lost World, he stayed there for five days recording as many sounds as he could typically within tropical areas. One day, he waited four hours for a hippopotamus to open its mouth for the sake of vocalization resulting in a worthwhile capture. Because Boyes wanted to record so many sounds, this was one of his many great techniques to avoid recycling sounds.

"My feeling is that foley really grounds everything in reality, almost giving an honest base to everything else. You can do this wonderful job of sound design and effects work, but until you have the foley there, it doesn't really glue everything together."

JOHNNIE BURN

Burn had worked on films such as Under The Skin, Poor Things, and Nope. According to Burn, the projects he would take on would include soundscapes that are going to be "interesting". He states that it's important to communicate with the director comparing it to a music conductor and a musician to make the soundscape "reflect the score". Burn has said that production crew members are given scores near the end of a typical production, which meant that no one had time to suggest any last-minute decisions. He would instead go over audio segments with other

sound designers postproduction to make suggestions to avoid future mistakes. Burn makes it clear that communication between a crew member and the director is a priority to create things efficiently on time.

BEN BURTT

Ben Burtt not only worked in sound engineering and design, but he was also the voice of the titular Pixar character, WALL-E and did Darth Vader's infamous breathing. He also created the lightsaber "hum" using a broken TV set and a film projector. Burtt has said that most of the sounds he created are from real-world objects, animals, or technology; a huge part of being a sound designer is going out there and documenting sound. Back when Burtt used to work with analog equipment, he said that it was rather heavy and found it a lot easier to work digitally as technology further advanced. By duplicating recordings, working with analog equipment degraded each sound; digitally was no longer an issue for Burtt.

Sources:

"How Sound Designer Johnnie Burn Mastered the Art of Immersive Sonic Storytelling." Composer Magazine - Spitfire Audio, composer.spitfireaudio.com/en/articles/how-sound-designer-johnnie-burn-mastered-the-art-of-immersive-sonic-storytelling. Accessed 8 July 2024.

sounddesignerprofiles, Written by. "Notable Techniques." Sound Designer Profiles: Christopher Boyes, 26 Feb. 2016, sounddesignerprofiles.wordpress.com/2016/02/25/notable-techniques/.

Tangcay, Jazz. "Ben Burtt, 'wall-E' and 'Star Wars' Voice Actor, Reflects on Creating Cinema's Most Famous Sounds with Academy Museum Installation." Variety, Variety, 22 Apr. 2023, variety.com/2023/artisans/news/ben-burtt-wall-e-star-wars-voice-actor-academy-museum-1235591162/.